



NEW ZEALAND · MCNZ

Registration for doctors

*The Medical Council route, what it asks
of you, and the checklist that goes with it.*

Ethicare Resourcing

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ethicareresourcing.com

What's inside

01 Registering with the Medical Council

This guide is free, and so is everything in it. Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date — so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.

Registering with the Medical Council

For international medical graduates — resident doctors and specialists alike. Three scopes, a pathway inside each, and a sequence that runs from a job offer through verification to a meeting in New Zealand before you can practise. The checklist is built into the page, so nothing you tick goes out of date.



Regulator

Medical Council of New Zealand — Te Kaunihera Rata o Aotearoa — under the Health Practitioners Competence Assurance Act 2003

Source

The Council's registration pathway pages at mcnz.org.nz, read 8 September 2026. Where this page and the Council differ, the Council is right.

Status

Checked 3 October 2026 against mcnz.org.nz — the registration pathway pages, the comparable health system criteria, the reference requirements, the scope-change policy and the variations page. Fees and English scores are not printed here because the Council revises them.

Fees & English scores

Deliberately not printed. The Council publishes both and revises them; check its fees page and English language policy before you budget or book.

AT A GLANCE

Three scopes, a pathway in each

General (resident doctors, RMOs, doctors in training), vocational (independent specialists) and special purpose (temporary). Which pathway you use depends on where you trained and where you have practised.

A job offer comes first

The pathways most international doctors use require one — with supervision for the comparable health system route, at consultant level for the specialist fast-track — and your employer completes part of the application.

Verification before submission

Your qualifications must be verified at source through EPIC before the Council will start on your file. Begin it early; it is the slowest step you control.

Registered in New Zealand, not before

A registration meeting after you arrive confirms identity and supervision. Only then is registration granted and a practising certificate issued — and most international graduates start under supervision. Not all: Australian graduates who completed an internship in Australia, and holders of approved Australasian postgraduate qualifications, may not be required to.

What's inside

Read it once to understand the shape of the journey, then come back to each section as you reach it. The checklist at the end remembers what you have ticked, on this device.

Understanding the Council

The three scopes

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The whole journey on one page

The checklist — 32 items, tickable

SECTION 01

Understanding the Council

The Medical Council of New Zealand — Te Kaunihera Rata o Aotearoa — registers doctors under the Health Practitioners Competence Assurance Act 2003 and is responsible for their competence, conduct and fitness to practise. Any doctor applying for registration must be fit for registration and fit to practise medicine; the Council determines this as part of assessing every application.

Registration, scope and practising certificate

Registration places you in a scope of practice. A practising certificate is what lets you work, and for international graduates it carries an endorsement naming your approved employment and supervision. You cannot practise until registration is confirmed and the certificate is issued, and you can only work within what the certificate says.

Start with the self-assessment tool

The Council publishes an online registration self-assessment tool that points you to the pathway you may be eligible for. It is the right first step before you gather a document or ask an employer for anything.

Job offer → Verification and application → Eligibility letter → Registration meeting in New Zealand → Practising certificate — supervised practice → Change of scope

SECTION 02

The three scopes

The Council has three main types of registration, which it calls scopes. Within each there are several pathways, and each pathway has its own requirements.

Resident doctors, RMOs, doctors in training

General scope

Preceded by a provisional general period under supervision. The scope most international doctors below consultant level register in.

Specialists working independently

Vocational scope

Permanent, specialist registration. International graduates enter through a provisional vocational period under supervision, then apply for the change of scope.

Temporary, for a specific purpose

Special purpose scope

Six categories: locum tenens, teleradiology, visiting expert, postgraduate training, research, and other special purposes such as a disaster or pandemic. Also supervised. Locum tenens, for twelve months or less, is a mainstream clinical route — but none of these is the way into a permanent post.

Every international graduate is supervised at first.

Whether you enter a provisional general, provisional vocational or special purpose scope, you work under a Council-approved supervisor while you become familiar with the New Zealand health system and its expected standard of practice.

— SECTION 03

General scope: which pathway is yours

Five pathways for doctors who trained outside New Zealand and Australia. Which one applies depends on where you qualified, where you are registered and where you have recently practised.

Competent Authority

UK and Irish medical graduates

A primary medical degree from the UK or Ireland, with your internship completed there.

Comparable health system

Recent experience in one of 29 recognised countries

At least 33 months of clinical practice, at 20 or more hours a week, in the 48 months before you apply — in the same or a similar area of medicine, at a similar level of responsibility to the New Zealand post — plus current full or general registration in one of those systems. A separate set of prerequisites exists for general practitioners with a recent postgraduate GP qualification.

Examinations

NZREX Clinical, PLAB 1 and 2, or the AMC exams

Passed within the last five years. This route also needs a job offer as a PGY1 in accredited clinical attachments with an accredited training provider, leading into the two-year prevocational training programme.

UK general registrants

PLAB, 12 months of UK practice, full GMC registration

PLAB Parts 1 and 2 passed within the last five years, full GMC general registration, and 12 months of UK practice that must be Foundation Year 1, FY2 stand-alone, or 12 months in an Approved Practice Setting. Progression also needs ACLS certification within the last 12 months and a minimum three-month supervision period before your supervisor can recommend you.

Australian general registrants

AMC examinations and Ahpra registration

Passed the Australian Medical Council examinations and registered with Ahpra.

Read the list, not the label.

The Council publishes the 29 comparable health systems and its criteria for them, and it adds countries from time to time. Whether your country is on it — and whether your recent months meet the 33-of-48 test at 20 hours a week — is what decides this pathway, not where you were born or trained.

— SECTION 04

Vocational scope: registering as a specialist

Four pathways. Two are for doctors who already hold an approved New Zealand or Australasian postgraduate qualification; the other two are for specialists trained elsewhere.

VOC1 and VOC2

Approved New Zealand or Australasian qualification

VOC1 if you already hold general scope registration; VOC2 if you do not.

VOC3 — provisional vocational

Trained and qualified as a specialist outside New Zealand and Australia

The Council assesses your training and qualifications on their merits, usually with advice from the relevant New Zealand college.

VOC4 — the fast-track

Approved UK, Irish or Australian postgraduate qualification

For specialists intending to work in an approved area of medicine. Prerequisites: an acceptable primary medical qualification; a postgraduate qualification on the Council's approved list; at least 24 months' clinical experience at 0.5 FTE or more in the past five years in that area, including 12 months within the last 18, in a comparable health system; and a job offer at consultant or specialist level. The Council states a processing time of 20 working days from a complete application; psychiatry may take longer.

Provisional first, vocational after

A successful international application leads to a provisional vocational period under supervision, during which the Council satisfies itself that you are competent to practise independently in your field. When you have completed the requirements it sets, you apply for the change of scope to vocational registration. Obstetrics and gynaecology, psychiatry and anatomical pathology carry additional information requirements.

Check the approved list, and its date.

The VOC4 list of approved postgraduate qualifications is a live document — the Council has added chemical pathology, haematology and microbiology to it. Confirm your qualification and area of medicine are on the current version before you plan around the fast-track.

SECTION 05

Primary source verification

Since November 2017 the Council has required key documents to be verified directly with the institution that issued them, through ECFMG's EPIC service — now accessed via the MyIntealth portal.

You must start this before you submit your application. The verification can take time, and the Council cannot begin processing until it has evidence that it is under way. Of everything in this guide it is the step most worth starting the day you decide to apply, because nothing you or your employer do afterwards can shorten it.

Create your EPIC account

Through the MyIntealth portal; ECFMG publishes instructions specific to New Zealand applicants.

2

Request verification of your primary medical qualification

EPIC contacts your medical school directly.

3

Request verification of your postgraduate qualification

If you are applying for a vocational scope.

4

Keep the evidence that verification is under way

It goes in with your application.

SECTION 06

References, English and fitness

The independent evidence behind your application — and the three things most often left late.

References

Three, on the Council's referee report form

The Council describes authentic, authoritative and comprehensive references as necessary to its decisions on fitness and competence, and the references go on its own RP6 referee report form. **Who verifies them depends on the scope you are applying for:** normally your prospective employer must make a declaration and provide evidence of having verified the reference. For provisional vocational and vocational applications the Council contacts the referee directly. Brief your referees either way.

English

The Council's English language policy

Every applicant must satisfy the Council that they can comprehend and communicate effectively in English in the medical workplace. The policy sets out the routes and any test requirement; scores are not reproduced here because the policy is revised. Check it before booking, and time any test to stay valid.

Fitness for registration

Health, conduct and competence

A legal requirement on the Council. Full, honest disclosure of anything relevant — even matters you consider minor or resolved — is always the right approach; non-disclosure is treated far more seriously than the underlying matter usually is.

SECTION 07

Applying with your employer

Applications are made online through the Council's portal, myMCNZ, and you complete them with your employer — some documents can only be completed by them.

Your employer applies for approval of the position and of your supervisor on the Council's form for your pathway, and the Council publishes a checklist for each pathway listing exactly what to submit. Processing times run from the date the Council receives a complete application, so the checklist is worth reading twice.

1

Request a PIN and create your myMCNZ account

2

Work through the Council's checklist for your pathway

Every document it lists, certified where required, clearly named.

3

Your employer completes the approval of position and supervisor form

Naming your post and your Council-approved supervisor.

4

Submit, with the fee

Fees are published on the Council's forms, fees and checklists page and revised; confirm before you pay.

5

Respond to any request promptly

The biggest factor within your control once the file is in.

6

Receive your eligibility for registration letter

It confirms for other agencies — Immigration New Zealand among them — that you can be registered, and gives you instructions for your registration meeting.

SECTION 08

The registration meeting and your practising certificate

Every international medical graduate coming to practise in New Zealand for the first time attends a registration meeting, and must be able to produce the information the Council has asked for.

The meeting confirms your identity, completes the registration formalities, takes your application for a practising certificate and settles your supervision. For the VOC4 fast-track it takes place within two weeks of your intended start date, and only once you have arrived in New Zealand. After the meeting, and once payment for the practising certificate is received, the Council grants registration in your provisional scope and issues the certificate — allow three days.

You cannot practise until then.

Registration must be confirmed and the practising certificate in your hands, and you may only work within the endorsement and any conditions noted on it. Plan your start date around the meeting, not the flight.

SECTION 09

Working under supervision, and progression

The provisional period is where the Council satisfies itself that you are ready for the scope you applied for. Three rules shape it.

1

Supervision is required

In every provisional general, provisional vocational and special purpose scope, under a Council-approved supervisor.

2

Variations before any change

Your practising certificate endorses a specific employment, supervision, position and location. If any of them change you apply for a variation at least 20 working days in advance, and wait for the Council's approval before starting under the new arrangement.

3

Progression is applied for, not automatic

Provisional general to general **depends on which pathway brought you in**. On the comparable health system and UK general registrant routes: 12 months full-time equivalent, three satisfactory supervision reports covering the nine months immediately before you apply, and your supervisor's recommendation. On the Competent Authority pathway for UK and Irish graduates it is shorter — six months full-time equivalent and two consecutive satisfactory reports. If you have not met them within 12 months you continue under supervision until you have. Provisional vocational to vocational: once you have completed the requirements Council set for you.

Conditions on the general scope

Your general scope is limited to the area of medicine you worked in during the provisional period — unless that was general practice, which carries no limitation. An unlimited general scope needs six months full-time equivalent of supervised practice in medicine and six months in surgery during your provisional general scope — and no more than three months of that medicine may be emergency medicine. Once in the general scope you are no longer supervised, but you must meet the Council's recertification requirements through the Inpractice programme or an accredited vocational training programme.

— WHERE PEOPLE GET STUCK

Almost every avoidable delay traces back to one of these

Verification started late

EPIC runs at the pace of your medical school. The Council cannot start until it is under way.

Counting months that do not count

The comparable health system test is 33 of the last 48 months, at 20 hours a week, in a similar area and level. Locum weeks or a different specialty may not qualify.

Assuming the label, not the list

A country you think of as comparable may not be on the Council's list; a qualification you think of as approved may not be on the VOC4 list.

Applying without a job offer

The comparable health system and VOC4 pathways need one — with supervision, or at consultant level.

Referees left unbriefed

At least three references, on the Council's RP6 form. Your employer verifies them for general and special purpose scopes; the Council does it directly for vocational. A slow referee is a slow application.

Booking the flight around the offer, not the meeting

Registration is granted after the meeting in New Zealand, and the certificate follows payment.

The fix for all of these

Run the self-assessment, start verification the same day, secure the offer, brief your referees, and read the Council's checklist for your pathway twice before you and your employer submit.

SECTION 11

The questions we are asked most

Which scope should I apply for?+

I trained in the UK or Ireland. Which pathway is mine?+

What counts as a comparable health system?+

Do I need a job offer before I apply?+

What is primary source verification?+

How long does the Council take?+

What is the registration meeting?+

Will I be supervised?+

How do I move from provisional general to general scope?+

Can Ethicare review my application?+

SECTION 12

The whole journey on one page

From first decision to first shift. Each stage links to the section that explains it; the checklist tracks the same stages.

Before you start

Self-assessment, scope, pathway

The Council's tool first; then general or vocational, and the pathway inside it. [Sections 02–04](#)

Before you start

Secure the job offer

With supervision, or at consultant level. Your employer is part of the application. [Section 07](#)

Start today

Primary source verification

EPIC via MyIntealth. Nothing starts at the Council until this is under way. [Section 05](#)

Preparing

References, English, fitness

Three referees on the Council's form; the English policy checked; full disclosure. [Section 06](#)

Applying

Submit via myMCNZ with your employer

Complete against the Council's checklist, with the fee. [Section 07](#)

Milestone

Eligibility for registration letter

The document Immigration New Zealand relies on.

Arrive

Registration meeting

Identity, formalities, supervision; then registration and the practising certificate. [Section 08](#)

Then

Supervised practice, then change of scope

12 months and three reports for general scope; the Council's set requirements for vocational. [Section 09](#)

Then

The life around the job

Where registration hands over to [planning your move](#).

Thirty-two items, in the order you will meet them

Tick as you go. Ticks are saved on this device only — nothing is sent to us — and the list is always the current version, which a downloaded copy never is.

0 of 32 ticked

[Clear all ticks](#)

01 Before you start

Scope, pathway and a job offer — in that order.

- ☐ **Run the Council's registration self-assessment tool** It points you to the pathway you may be eligible for. Do it before a single document.
- ☐ **Decide the scope you are applying for** General (resident doctor, RMO, in training) or vocational (independent specialist). Special purpose is temporary.
- ☐ **Confirm your pathway within that scope** Competent Authority, comparable health system, examinations, UK or Australian general registrant; or VOC1–VOC4 for specialists.
- ☐ **Secure a job offer** With supervision for the comparable health system pathway; at consultant or specialist level for VOC4.
- ☐ **Note the current fees** Registration, the practising certificate and third-party costs. Check the Council's live fees page.

02 Check the pathway prerequisites

Each pathway has its own tests. These are the ones most international doctors meet.

- ☐ **An acceptable primary medical qualification** Check your medical school against the Council's acceptable-qualifications list.
- ☐ **Comparable health system: 33 months in the last 48** Clinical practice at 20 or more hours a week, in one or more of the 29 recognised countries, in a similar area and at a similar level to the New Zealand post.
- ☐ **Comparable health system: current full or general registration** With the regulator of at least one comparable system worked in during those 48 months.
- ☐ **VOC4: an approved postgraduate qualification** On the Council's approved list, in an approved area of medicine.
- ☐ **VOC4: 24 months at 0.5 FTE or more in the past five years** Including 12 months within the last 18, in a comparable health system, in that area of medicine.
- ☐ **Meet the fitness for registration requirements** Health, conduct and competence — full, honest disclosure.

03 Primary source verification — start this first

The Council cannot begin processing until it is under way.

- ☐ **Open an EPIC account via the MyIntealth portal** ECFMG's Electronic Portfolio of International Credentials.
- ☐ **Request verification of your primary medical qualification** Sent directly from your medical school.
- ☐ **Request verification of your postgraduate qualification, if applying for a vocational scope**
- ☐ **Keep the evidence that verification is under way** You upload it with your application.

04 References, CV and English

The independent evidence.

- ☐ **Three referees on the Council's referee report form** At least three, on form RP6. Your employer verifies them — the Council does so itself only for vocational applications.
- ☐ **CV on the Council's template where one is specified** VOC4 has its own CV template.
- ☐ **Meet the Council's English language policy** Check the current routes and any test requirement before booking; time a test to stay valid.
- ☐ **Additional information for certain specialties** Obstetrics and gynaecology, psychiatry and anatomical pathology have extra forms or requests.

05 Apply with your employer

Some documents can only be completed by them.

- ☐ **Request a PIN and create your myMCNZ account**
- ☐ **Employer completes the approval of position and supervisor form** Names your position and your Council-approved supervisor.
- ☐ **Submit a complete application with the fee** Processing time runs from receipt of a complete application.
- ☐ **Respond promptly to any Council request** Speed of response is the biggest factor within your control.
- ☐ **Eligibility for registration letter received** Confirms for Immigration New Zealand that you can be registered, and sets out your registration meeting.

06 Arrive, meet, register

Registration is confirmed in New Zealand, not before.

- ☐ **Attend your registration meeting** Identity, formalities, practising certificate application, supervision. For VOC4, within two weeks of your start date.
- ☐ **Pay for your practising certificate** Allow three days after the meeting for it to be issued.
- ☐ **Do not practise until registration is confirmed and you hold the certificate** Work only within the endorsement and conditions on it.

07 Under supervision, then progression

What the provisional period asks of you.

- ☐ **Work under your Council-approved supervisor** Required in every provisional and special purpose scope.
- ☐ **Apply for a variation before anything changes** Employment, supervision, position or location — at least 20 working days in advance, and wait for approval.
- ☐ **Provisional general: 12 months FTE, three satisfactory supervision reports, supervisor recommendation** Then apply for general scope — it is not automatic.
- ☐ **Provisional vocational: complete the requirements Council sets** Then apply for change of scope to vocational.
- ☐ **Meet recertification requirements once in the general scope** In practice, or an accredited vocational training programme.

Print or save as PDF

WHAT NEXT?

Registration is one part of the decision

Check my pathwayRegistration and eligibility only — scope, pathway and the months that count, before you gather a single document. **How registration works in New Zealand**For every profession — the councils and boards, the sequence, English and timelines. **Medicine in New Zealand**The family of medical roles, and the pages for each. **Pay agreements**The ASMS MECA for senior doctors and the RMO agreements — the verification register. **Plan your move**Registration, visas, family and the order to do it in — personalised, saved in your browser.

HOW WE HELP

We can read it before the Council does

We help you identify the pathway, sequence verification and references so nothing waits on anything else, and read the file against the Council's checklist before you and your employer submit. We support and guide you through the process; the registration decision always rests with the Medical Council of New Zealand.

Talk to Ethicare

[The Council's own site ↗](#)